



Urban Design Topic Paper

July 2023



Introduction

Coventry enjoys a rich history of architectural innovation and continual development, the city enjoys an environment where markedly different periods of development and associated architectural styles may be experienced in close proximity, thus delivering a highly legible built form narrative to the city. In seeking to both respect these markers of development periods and also continually evolve as a city, the creative role of urban design in the built environment is critical in delivering positive environments which benefit the wellbeing of the city, contribute positively toward the challenge of the changing climate, attract inward investment, whilst also responding positively to established built form precedents which are a key marker of the cities identity.

Plans, Policies and Programmes

The National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) 2021 and National Planning Practice Guidance (NPPG) which supplements the NPPF, places significant weight on good design as a means of bringing about sustainable development, creating better places, and delivering development which is suitable and appropriate for the communities where it takes place.

Paragraph 130 sets out how planning policy and decisions should ensure that development:

- a) will function well and add to the overall quality of the area, not just for the short term but over the lifetime of the development;
- b) are visually attractive as a result of good architecture, layout and appropriate and effective landscaping;
- c) are sympathetic to local character and history, including the surrounding built environment and landscape setting, while not preventing or discouraging appropriate innovation or change (such as increased densities);
- d) establish or maintain a strong sense of place, using the arrangement of streets, spaces, building types and materials to create attractive, welcoming and distinctive places to live, work and visit;
- e) optimise the potential of the site to accommodate and sustain an appropriate amount and mix of development (including green and other public space) and support local facilities and transport networks; and
- f) create places that are safe, inclusive and accessible and which promote health and wellbeing, with a high standard of amenity for existing and future users; and where crime and disorder, and the fear of crime, do not undermine the quality of life or community cohesion and resilience.

The NPPF further requires that the greatest possible amount of clarity on what is expected with respect to design outcomes and requirements is facilitated as early as possible in the development process (para 128). It promotes the use of tools such as design guides and codes within instruments including local plans and supplementary planning documents to create a

framework setting design standards and requirements, with the level of detail or prescription tailored to the specific setting.

National Design Guide

The National Design Guide is a material consideration and forms part of national planning guidance setting out the characteristics of well-designed places and demonstrating what the government considers good design to mean in practice. The guide outlines and illustrates ten characteristics of good design falling under the topics of Climate, Character and Community. The characteristics range from context, identity and built form, through to nature, public space, movement, and the uses on the site including homes and buildings, the resources used to construct them and their life span.

Nationally Described Space Standards (NDSS)

In 2015, the UK Government created the Nationally Described Space Standard (NDSS) as a supporting document to the national Planning Practice Guidance for Local Planning Authorities to use where it is deemed necessary and viable. Standards for internal space were set out within the 'Technical housing standards. The NDSS sets out minimum requirements for: gross internal area (GIA) for each dwelling type (combination of bedspaces and number of storeys); bedroom types in dwellings with two or more bed spaces; Floor space of each bedroom type; widths of each bedroom type; floor to ceiling height; headroom; and storage.

Proposed Changes to the Planning System/National Model Design Code

In 2020 the government published a set of proposed wide-ranging reforms to the planning system, which were put to consultation. A notable portion of the proposed reforms was a systematic and universally applied approach to ensuring high quality design and “beauty” in development schemes as well as an enhanced role for local communities in the design aspect of the development process. To that end a draft National Model Design Code (NMDC) has been published which builds off the recently published National Design Guide discussed above. The Code can be used as is or serve as a framework for local authorities to develop their own localised codes.

Current Local Plan UD Situation

In respect of promoting high quality architectural and urban design, alongside national policy, the City Council currently primarily refers to local plan policy DE1 which seeks to promote positive design principles in built form, responsive to local character and quality, policy DE1 states :

- 1. All development proposals must respect and enhance their surroundings and positively contribute towards the local identity and character of an area.*
- 2. The setting, integrity and character of heritage assets will be protected in accordance with Policy HE2.*
- 3. All development will be expected to meet the following key principles:*
 - a. respond to the physical context of the site;*

- b. consider the local distinctiveness and identity of the site but also have regard to opportunities to enhance the local built and natural environment through new development and enhanced design;*
- c. where appropriate, retain and incorporate into the layout the protection of important views, including key views of the three spires;*
- d. preserve or enhance the character and setting of the historic built, landscape and where appropriate archaeological environment;*
- e. preserve or enhance the character and setting of major road, rail and canal corridors;*
- f. clearly define the boundaries between public and private spaces and enclosure of space;*
- g. provide attractive, safe, uncluttered, active and easily identifiable, high quality public spaces;*
- h. make places that inter-connect and are easy to move through;*
- i. ensure places are easily understood by users, with clear routes and distinct physical features;*
- j. seek high quality design and attention to detail in the layout of developments, individual buildings and infrastructure in terms of function and impact, not just for the short term, but over the lifetime of the development;*
- k. be adaptable to changing social, technological, economic and market conditions and ensure that developments maximise the use of the site;*
- l. promote diversity through mixes of uses within a site or building, which work together to create vital and viable places;*
- m. be proactive in responding to climate change and adopt sustainable and low carbon construction principles in terms of their design, layout and density;*
- n. consider green infrastructure at the earliest stage in the design process, to ensure that it is well planned, designed, managed and maintained. It should also be well integrated and serve multiple purposes (as appropriate);*
- o. support the integration of through routes for public transport and incorporate suitable bus priority measures as appropriate;*
- p. minimise adverse impact on important natural resources;*
- q. conserve, restore or enhance biodiversity; and*
- r. respect and enhance landscape quality including trees, hedges and other landscape features of value.*

Building upon the foundations set within DE1 and in seeking to further articulate design parameters which may yield best outcomes the authority continues to develop supplementary design guides to sit alongside this core policy, as follows:

Recently adopted design led policy

- New Build Residential Development Design Guide
- Tall Buildings Design Guide and Three Spires View Management Framework

Design led SPD's currently in draft / being consulted upon

- Householder Design Guide

Forthcoming design led policy works

- Localised Coventry design code
- Shop front design guide

Recent and Emerging Challenges

The challenges which arose through the pandemic and beyond are key informatives to the review of design policy for the city, as constraints highlighted by existing built form stock should be recognised and challenged in new build design, whilst also anticipating the embedded change to working patterns and the resultant effect on district roles.

During the pandemic the crucial role of external amenity space, both regarding quality and quantum, has been further reinforced. Amenity space can be considered in both the public and private basis and its range of function in the public sense is wide, seeking to cater for a full range of user groups, playing roles both in a passive and active sense, and contributing to local identity and legibility. Looking ahead in the development of policy in this regard, the variety of demands upon these spaces should be carefully considered in order to ensure these valuable spaces best enact their roles for the benefit of all user groups.

In respect of private amenity space, a key constraint of apartment living was observed in this respect where external amenity space has often been limited in nature, and when internal, its communal nature made its use very restricted in the period of the pandemic. Careful consideration should therefore be given in ensuring opportunities for the delivery of external amenity space, both communal and private to be integrated into forthcoming development of this type, utilising roof areas, stepped building forms, external terraces and winter garden arrangements offer opportunities for embedding high quality amenity space.

Noting the shifts in working patterns evident both during and post the Covid pandemic, the role of office districts and the supporting economies may be challenged in forthcoming years, with the opportunity for redevelopment of such areas already being seen to be explored, as such it is recommended that the authority should seek to explore what positive development of such areas may constitute. It is also noted that the city does not currently offer a range of opportunities for 'touch-down' working spaces which offer environments for those who do not work in traditional office environments to utilise and encourage this activity to support existing centres, seeking to embed such uses in wider district planning in order to support sustainable working communities may be a key point of focus when establishing design and use criteria for larger scale redevelopment proposals.

Climate Change

Recognition of the changing climate and the challenges arising from this should be at the forefront of architectural design proposals emerging in the city, whilst the existing local plan policy (3m,n) embed this principle currently and building regulations continue to develop to drive energy efficiencies, development of local plan design policies to strengthen the necessity for the recognition of this agenda should be sought. The use of renewable technologies integrated into new building design, alongside the enquiry of embedded energy costs of new development could be established as a key principle in design assessments. The crucial integration of adaptability in new design and encouragement of such change in existing built form stock also provides opportunity for the reduction in overall energy impacts of redevelopment.

How a new local plan may respond positively to the challenges and trends identified :

Notwithstanding DE1 and associated forthcoming supplementary planning documents, development of the core design policy is identified as an opportunity in seeking to encourage response to the current Urban Design landscape, these aims are aligned to the national agenda of Climate, Character and Community, and established alongside the evolving social and economic informatics, these may be summarised in four key topic areas as follows; -

- **Embedding economic sustainability in design**
 - Evidence adaptability in new build design in order that the built form stock of the city may be best able to adapt to changing market trends, thus reinforcing the cities ability to accommodate economic change.
 - A key driver of a wider environmental agenda, positive and pro-active principles of adaptability in building design may significantly reduce the wider energy impacts of development proposals.
- **Embedding social sustainability principles**
 - Accommodating an ageing population, incorporation into local plan policy the outcomes of HAPPI design guidance, whilst positively promoting generational community mixing in master planning.
 - Mixture of tenures and accommodation types – the positive building of neighbourhoods and communities inclusive of tenure blind development, alongside supporting infrastructure – ‘integrated neighbourhood principles’
 - Commitment to exploration of the introduction of internal space standards articulated in NDSS, considering impacts upon viability. Thereafter if need is evidenced, the incorporation of NDSS standards through planning condition in new build residential schemes to ensure housing stock positively meets the needs of users.
- **A promotion of ‘responsive architectural innovation’**
 - Addressing and enveloping national design policy direction
 - Reinforcing and celebrating the cities legacy of architectural innovation
 - Seeking to promote a new period of the cities architectural legacy, reinforcing Coventry’s identity as a city for built environment innovation
- **Principles of wellbeing and local Identity in design**
 - External amenity principles – the lessons from the Covid Pandemic
 - The role of public space, delivering positive, distinctive places, locally identifiable space between buildings
 - Embedding the principles of the building for a healthy life principle
 - Streets for all, ensuring design guidance also appropriately addresses the requirement of public space considerations, catering for the wide range of users and uses whilst encouraging social interaction.

Likely Trends

The existing design local plan policy DE1 is seen to set a sound basis on which to test architectural and urban design proposals in the city through the planning process, however the lessons of the pandemic, resultant, and ongoing economic revisions, alongside the climate change agenda have highlighted areas where the existing policy may have opportunity to evolve further to address several contemporary challenges in the city. Urban Design therefore proposes that in review, an ongoing commitment to build a further evidence base which ,may inform policy utilisation and alignment to the identified trends is incorporated, in order that the city may not be constrained in its ability to require new development to continue to

contribute to key wellbeing and climate change agendas. Contributions may include adherence to nationally described space standards for new residential uses and seeking to embed the highest sustainability principles in architectural and urban design proposals ahead of a proposals interaction with an evolving national building regulations system at later technical design stages.

Similarly, regarding the development and recognition of the cities legacy as a place of built form innovation, the current design policies could be further developed to promote responsive and innovative architectural approaches which also accord to the national design policy direction and offer further opportunities of architectural contributions to the climate change and biodiversity agendas of the city. Without such innovation the city could be at risk of stagnation of design approaches which may undermine the cities wider identity as a place to be celebrated for its promotion of creative approach to townscape, it is however suggested that such articulations could also be successfully contained within supporting supplementary guidance, alongside the Local Plan policy base of DE1.